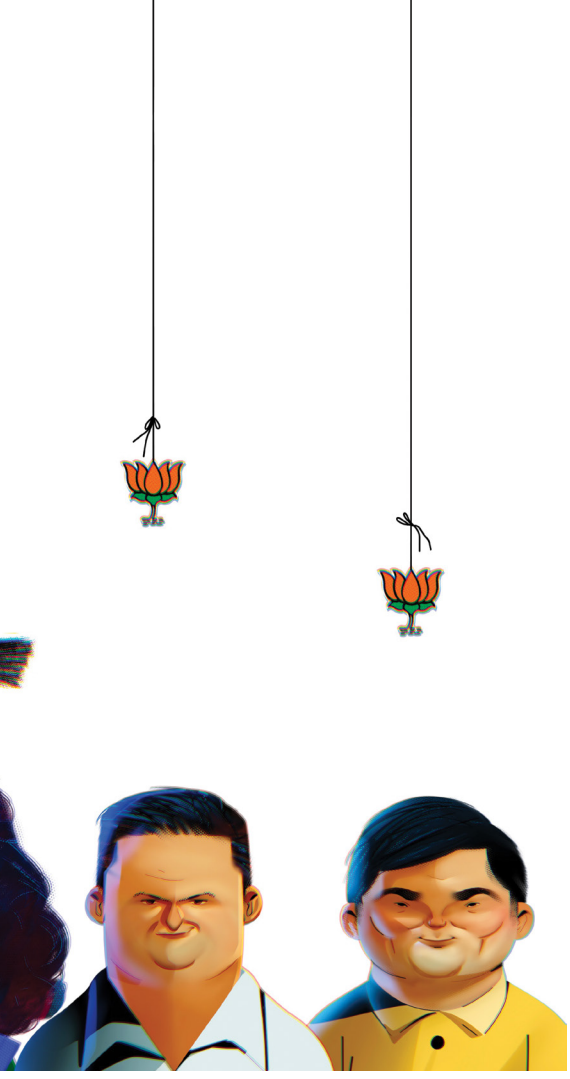


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

to form the government despite emerging as the single-largest party with 17 seats. The BJP beckoned—an attractive offer since the party was much better at forming governments. He won a bypoll and duly became health minister. Two of his former confreres, Subhash Shirodkar and Dayanand Sopte, followed in October 2018. They too won bypolls from Shiroda and Mandre, respectively. Over time, that slow blood loss became a case of full-blown haemorrhage. The Congress goes into election with its 2017 tally of 17 reduced to two.

One catalyst for this was the late Manohar Parrikar. As chief minister, he led a coalition government comprising the BJP, the Maharashtrawadi Gomantak Party (MGP), the Goa Forward Party (GFP) and three independents. The new incumbent, Pramod Sawant, ended the association with the MGP and GFP, sacking the two deputy CMs from those parties, Sudin Dhavalikar and Vijai Sardesai, within 10 days. Helpfully, two of the three MGP MLAs broke away and merged their group into BJP.

Over time, the slow blood loss became a case of full-blown haemorrhage for Congress

The Congress pegged one back when it won the Panaji bypoll in May 2019 (necessitated by Parrikar's death). The score now was—BJP: 16, Congress: 15. But just two months later, the GOP received its biggest jolt as 10 of its 15 MLAs rebelled against the party, formed a separate group, and later merged it with the BJP. The BJP now had 26 and Sawant became their first CM to have two-thirds majority in the House.

After a two-year lull, in October 2021, then state Congress chief Luizinho Faleiro defected to the TMC, marking that party's re-entry in Goa after 2012. That set off a whole feeding frenzy all around. The only one to swim against the current was Michael Lobo—he left the BJP for the Congress, miffed at wife Delailah being denied a ticket. Former BJP chief minister Laxmikant Parsekar left the party a wee more embarrassed by quitting too. He will contest as an independent. ■

–with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Kaushik Deka, Kiran D. Tare and Prashant Srivastava

UP

TWO DOWN

There's no telling what effect words can have. Days after Priyanka Gandhi said, only half in jest, that there was "no other face" in UP, the Congress has lost two of its recognisable faces...from its already slim roster of recognisable faces! R.P.N. Singh, the former Union MoS for home who retains a footprint in native Kushinagar as ex-royalty, has decided to start "a new chapter". The other: Imran Masood, former party secretary and a name to reckon with in Saharanpur. Just a day ago, a video had gone viral where Imran was talking about his humiliation at the hands of the Samajwadi Party. The next day, hey presto, he had jumped ship. What explained the yo-yo motion? Say SP sources: "Earlier, Imran wanted two tickets, one for himself, one for his aide—and got annoyed when that didn't happen. Later, he tried for a BSP ticket but Akhileshji somehow managed to retain him." ■



UTTARAKHAND

KHANDURI, STILL ZAROORI

In 2012, BJP campaign workers painted the walls in Uttarakhand with the slogan, 'Khanduri Hai Zaroori'. He was seen as the party's fulcrum here, and ticked all boxes–the army veteran, with firebrand oratory to match, stood out with his clean image and can-do spirit. Cut to the present, and for a while the contrast was stark: the BJP seemed all too eager to bury that chapter. B.C. Khanduri was forced to retire in 2019, citing the 75-year age criterion. His US-returned son Manish was next to be denied a ticket. But those who were calling it the end of the Khanduri era are eating their words. Daughter Ritu has bucked the trend with a ticket from family fief Kotdwar, in the Pauri region. ■